conviction, but out of a simple desire for power. (This later became obvious when he was at the helm. Between 1971–9, Honecker expressed willingness to talk to the Bonn government, worked for the liberalisation of art and opened the market economy). For his part, Ulbricht had publicly snubbed his disciple on several occasions, and according to his adopted daughter, Beate Ulbricht, her father complained that Honecker had ‘fallen on his head as a roofer and suffered permanent damage’. A few years earlier, in July 1963, Ulbricht had used Honecker’s vacation-related absence to weaken his power base by removing his confidant Paul Verner as the new head of the youth commission and replaced him with an old rival Kurt Turba (who had been fired by Honecker in 1953).

Meanwhile, Brezhnev’s growing distaste for the NES was demonstrated in September 1965 when Erich Apel – the man entrusted to coordinate economic reforms – was snubbed during trade negotiations in Moscow when his interlocutors fell far short of his requests for crude oil and steel. Thereafter, he was excluded from further GDR-Soviet trade talks after expressing horror at plans for the GDR to pay for Russian coal with high-quality equipment, textile machines, diesel engines, locomotives and ships. Furthermore, the Soviets openly criticized Apel’s efforts to orientate the GDR economy toward Western technology rather than Russian experience, defeating his efforts to look outside the socialist bloc for research, technology and science. Alexander Schalck-Golodkowski, who later became a key figure in GDR economics, said Ulbricht’s NES was the ‘proclamation of an independent path for the GDR’, and meant ‘a certain departure from the rigid model of the planned economy in the Soviet Union’.1

As the NES problem simmered, Brezhnev’s stance helped open a new front for disenchanted old hands. Brimming with confidence, the anti-reform majority in the Politburo expanded attacks on the work of the State Planning Commission, prompting Ulbricht – sensing which way the wind was blowing – to drop his support for Apel, a stunning betrayal. Then, at a meeting of the Politburo on 2 December, the sense of conflict grew when Willi Stoph led the charge by calling for state planning to be recentralised and criticised the ‘inept’ work of Apel who was panned, if not derided, from all sides. Having lost his reputation in the SED and weary of signing